

EMPIRES



A LARGE SUPER-STATE under a single ruler is called an empire. There have been many different empires through history, from the ancient Roman Empire to the great empire of the Incas in Peru. The largest ever was the British Empire. Most empires have an army, to conquer territory and suppress revolts, and a civil service to carry out the day-to-day running of the empire and collect taxes. No empire lasts for ever – though the effect on the host country may be permanent – and empires perish for many reasons, including internal rebellion, economic decline, or the sheer difficulty of uniting many peoples under one leader.

Ottoman sword and scabbard



Growth of empires

Empires grow because ruling powers want extra income from trade or taxes, or they may have territorial ambitions. Sometimes they may want to spread a religion. Would-be empires always need a strong army.

Ottoman Empire

The Ottoman Turks expanded their empire by military might. At their height in the 17th century, they dominated the Mediterranean coast from present-day Greece to Tunisia.

Imperial cross



Holy Roman Empire

Based in Germany, the leaders of this empire saw themselves as heirs to the Roman emperors. The emperors wanted to wield religious power over all western Christians, and to exert political power over the other European rulers, such as the German and Italian princes.

British Empire

The largest empire the world has ever seen had its beginnings in the 18th and early 19th centuries, when Britain acquired Australia, Canada, and a range of territories from Honduras to Hong Kong. The "jewel in the crown" of the empire was India, which Britain dominated through the East India Company. Queen Victoria (r.1837–1901) took the title Empress of India in 1876. The British Empire had a lasting influence on its territories – for both good and bad. British-style administration provided a model for local civil servants when territories gained independence. On the other hand, the British exploited local labour forces on a massive scale.

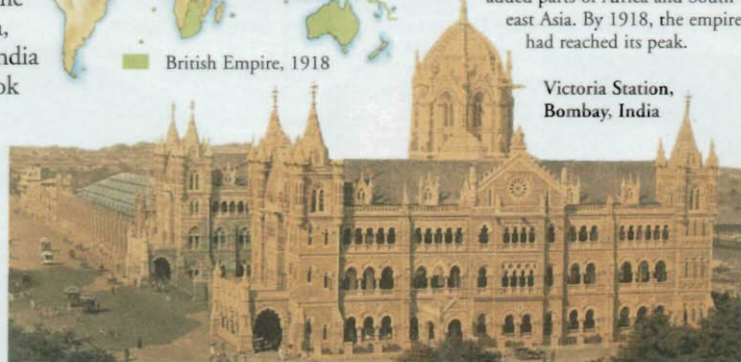


British Empire, 1918

Extent of the empire

After winning the Napoleonic Wars, and the decline of the older empires of Spain, Portugal, and the Netherlands, Britain was clearly one of the world's strongest countries. As the 19th century wore on, the already vast British Empire added parts of Africa and South-east Asia. By 1918, the empire had reached its peak.

Victoria Station, Bombay, India



Gordon of Khartoum

In 1884, two years after Egypt became part of the empire, General Charles Gordon (1833–85) came to the Sudan to aid Egyptians defending their garrisons against a local revolt. Gordon was cut off in the city of Khartoum and withstood a 10-month siege, but was finally killed. There was an outcry that a relief force had not been sent quickly enough to save Gordon, and he became a hero of the empire.



Resources of the empire

Britain had limited resources but an expanding industry, so the British used their empire as a source of raw materials, and a market for goods. The far-flung empire provided raw materials, such as cotton, gemstones, and hard wood, and raw materials included tea, rubber, tin, copper, and wool.



Cotton



Emerald



Timber

Public works

The British made the major towns of the empire as similar to British cities as possible. They sent British engineers and architects all over the world to build government headquarters, churches, railway stations, art galleries, and public buildings. Former imperial cities, such as Bombay, still have Victorian-era administration and transport centres.

Timeline

509 BC–AD 476 Roman Empire dominates much of Europe, western Asia, and northern Africa.

221–206 BC Qin emperor unites China.

321–187 BC Mauryans rule much of India.

395–1453 Byzantine Empire established in the eastern territory of the Roman Empire.

962–1806 Holy Roman Empire dominates central Europe.



Conquistadore's helmet

1206–1405 Mongols create an empire, including most of Asia.

1345–1521 Aztec emperors hold power in Mexico.

1521–1825 Spain builds large empire in southern America.

1580–1931 British Empire increases in size.

1930s British Empire starts to decline. By the 1940s, territories are claiming independence.

Imperialism

The economic domination of Asia, North America, and Africa by Europe, the United States, and Russia from the 17th century is known as modern imperialism. Ancient imperialism peaked with the Roman Empire.



The bear, symbol of Russia, 1888

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